Source: Social media handles of the RSS, the BJP and Narendra Modi; Google Playstore, 30 August 2020

In the Vajpayee years, they explained, the party used to charge ₹3 as a membership fee for ordinary members, who had to fill in a paper form to join the party for a six-year term. This basic fee was increased in the early 2000s to ₹5. The party also had another higher category of more involved workers, the sakriya sadasya, or active members, who paid up ₹100 for a three-year term. Their active status allowed them to stand for and contest local party positions.

When Amit Shah launched the first post-Modi membership campaign in 2014, the party made a number of innovations. It abolished the paperwork required for new members and replaced it with digital enrolment. All an aspiring member had to do was call a toll-free number—18002662020—and the membership fee was waived off. This is why Opposition leaders initially reacted to the BJP's recruitment drive with mirth. 'If it were not tragic for democracy, it would be comic,' Congress spokesperson Abhishek Manu Singhvi said in March 2015. 'If by pressing a button you can get one crore membership in one week, you can imagine the commitment to ideology, the commitment to a party.'[20] What many did not factor in was that the party followed up each of these missed calls with a verification link sent directly to the caller's phone. 'After the missed call, you get a link sent to your phone. On that, you fill your name and verification and send back. Only then do you become a member,' said District Vice President Hemant Agarwal.[21]

Moreover, digital enrolments allowed the party to create a new technology-enabled layer of checks and balances for its existing rank and file. In earlier recruitment drives, party officials charged with executing them had to fill up names of new members 'on paper', said another long-time local leader.[22] But that system could be manipulated by ambitious local party officials looking to gain easy brownie points with their superiors by fudging numbers. To get around that problem, the BJP created a new rule. It told party members that only those who enrolled 100 new members would qualify to be a sakriya sadasya (active member). This was important,